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Compensation: What to Look for in an Esports Professional Player Contract

Congrats! You're skilled enough at your favorite video game that an Esports organization wants to sign you to its team. Since this is the first time you've had this experience, you're very excited and ready to sign your contract as soon as possible. But wait a moment and consider the importance of the document you're about to sign. Salary and term length aren't the only forms of compensation you need to consider.

Salary

While you shouldn't focus solely on money, you should ensure you're being offered a realistic and fair salary for your skill level and Esport title. For example, if you're a starting professional player in League of Legends (LoL), you should be offered a minimum of \$75,000 USD a year. That's because Riot Games, the creator of LoL, has mandated a minimum of \$75,000 for all starting players. Many newer LoL players can make more than this, with \$100,000 USD becoming an increasingly standard salary. Not all Esports players are as fortunate, though. Super Smash Brothers' (SSB) salaries, for example, are significantly lower. If you're a new top player signed to SSB, it's common to receive a salary close to \$6,000-\$18,000 USD a year, depending on the organization. Many top players will earn \$24,000-\$40,000 USD a year, with the upper range reserved for those who've placed top five in the world. When it comes to negotiating your salary, it pays to be familiar with the salaries of other professional players, especially those playing the same Esport title at a similar skill level as yours.

Bonuses

Bonuses are another important form of compensation. Bonuses can be awarded for high placements in tournaments, reaching a predetermined placement in a season, beating specific teams or players, completing a certain number of streaming hours, etc. Some specific examples of bonuses I've seen include: \$5,000 (USD) awarded to new LoL players for reaching the finals of playoffs; \$10,000 (USD) awarded for making "Worlds" the biggest tournament in League of Legends; and \$10,000 (USD) for advancing beyond the group stage at "Worlds." Similar to negotiating a salary, research the kinds of bonuses other professional players with your skill level and Esport title are receiving in their contracts.

Relocation & Housing

Professional players often must move to their new team's location. You don't want to have to worry about locating and paying for your own lodging, so housing stipulations should be a part of your contract. Once you've stipulated that housing must be covered in your contract, it's crucial to get the specifics in writing. Otherwise, you may not get comfortable housing. Consider asking for your own room, air conditioning, and proximity to amenities and competitions venues.

Food

Food is included in every contract I've helped write. Not having to worry about paying for or sourcing food will allow you to focus on practicing and competing. Some professional players on top-tier Esports teams request personal chefs and special food services. Professional players on lower-tier teams may get their organizations to cover 5-7 days of meals each week.

Insurance

Stipulating insurance coverage in your contract is essential. You need health, dental, and vision benefits just like any other employee. Playing an Esport professionally is very taxing and may require you to undergo physical therapy for injuries, counseling to deal with the stress of your career path, or eye exams to obtain corrective eyewear.

Internet & Computer

Computers and an Internet connection are usually accounted for in contracts due to the nature of Esports, but it's still smart to ask your organization to provide exactly what you need to be productive and comfortable. Unless you are specific in your requests, the organization may only provide a standard computer and accessories.

Once you (or your agent) has looked over the multiple forms of compensation in the contract, hire a lawyer to review it. If all your requests have been honored, you're good to sign! If not, you'll have to decide if not getting your preferred computer brand, for example, is a deal breaker. When making this decision, remember that contract terms can frequently change, depending on your talent level and experience. You can ask for more when it's time to re-sign once you have some professional experience under your belt. You might even ask to renegotiate your contract before it expires, depending on your success. The sky's the limit, but you'll have to continue working on your gameplay and demonstrate why you deserve more in subsequent contract negotiations. Good luck!